

725 Interview Skills

(formerly 515)

Description & Eligibility

Contestants will demonstrate job search and interview readiness through professional communication, employability skills, and career preparation. Contestants will create a resume and cover letter, research career qualifications, and participate in a formal interview. Evaluation will focus on written and oral communication, professional image, workplace ethics, and interpersonal effectiveness in an in-person setting. Any secondary or postsecondary division contestant may enter this application event. Contestants may *not* enter both Interview Skills and Advanced Interview Skills in the same year. This event may *not* be repeated. Contestants must be registered for the national competition before the submission deadline and compete in both parts of the event to be ranked.

Contestant Must Supply

- One (1) copy of your resume and cover letter submitted at presentation check-in (both preliminaries and finals)

Contest Notes

- Method of evaluation: judged
- AI Policy Level 1 *No AI Allowed*
- Length of event: no more than fifteen (15) minutes for interview
- Each state is allowed three (3) entries
- Finals may be part of the competition

Technical Pre-Submit Specifications

What to Submit at https://upload.bpa.org	Saved File Name(s)	National Deadline
Submit one combined PDF file: 1. Resume 2. Cover Letter	IS-ContestantID.pdf	April 1, 2027, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time

Contest Competencies

1. Create a professional Applicant Tracking System (ATS) optimized, résumé and cover letter demonstrating employability, career-readiness skills, and alignment with industry expectations
2. Research career pathways, job requirements, and advancement opportunities using credible resources and professional networks
3. Demonstrate a professional image and strong communication skills through effective verbal and nonverbal interaction
4. Apply workplace ethics, professional conduct, and respect for diverse work environments
5. Demonstrate effective, professional responses to judge questions using clear, relevant, example-based communication

Contest Specifications for this Event

- Business cards, thank you notes, etc. are not permitted
- Contestant will indicate on his/her resume the position for which he/she is applying. There are openings in all departments of Digital Solutions shown on the Organizational Chart found in the *Style & Reference Manual*
- Resume work/volunteer history must be in reverse chronological order
- Contestant may interview for any position listed on the organizational chart for which he/she is qualified
- Contestants who do not apply for one of the designated positions will be *disqualified*

- Information in the cover letter and resume must be authentic; however, contestants may choose to use a fictitious personal address and telephone number. The use of references on the resume is optional
- The cover letter must be addressed as follows:
 Ms. Julie Smith, Manager
 Human Resources Department
 Digital Solutions
 1365 King Avenue
 Columbus, OH 43212

Common Specifications for all BPA Judged Events

- This is a pre-submitted event. Regional and state conferences have specific deadlines prior to the national deadlines. Please consult the regional or state conference administrator for those deadlines. For the National Leadership Conference, submit project files at <https://upload.bpa.org> no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time on April 1, 2027.
- An auto-generated confirmation will be provided upon project submission for the National Leadership Conference; individual confirmation cannot be provided. No changes can be made to the project after the date of submission.
- Contestant ID is required for all submissions. Materials from non-registered contestants and/or those missing Contestant ID cannot be accepted.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will *not* be returned and will *not* be available at NLC.

725 Interview Skills

Technical Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Materials indicate contestant applied for one of the positions shown on the Organizational Chart of Digital Solutions found in the <i>Style & Reference Manual</i> .				☐ Y ☐ N
If no to the question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Submission and Formatting (All points or none are awarded by the technical judge)				
Contestant submitted their Cover Letter and Resume in one (1) combined PDF file.				/10
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-3 points	Meets Expectations 4-7 points	Above Expectations 8-10 points	Points Awarded
Cover Letter				
Introduction and Address	Introduction is missing or vague, lacks clarity or relevance.	Somewhat engaging but lacks specificity or impact.	Engaging and specific, effectively captures attention.	/10
Relevance of Skills	Skills are not relevant to the position or not mentioned at all.	Some relevant skills are mentioned but may not be clearly tied to the position or fully explained.	All skills are clearly relevant to the position, well-explained, and directly applicable to the requirements.	/10
Closing Statement	Missing or ineffective, fails to summarize key points.	Basic closing present but lacks impact.	Strong, compelling summary leaves a memorable impression.	/10
Writing Accuracy	Numerous errors impacting clarity.	Few errors, minor impact on clarity.	Error-free, polished grammar and spelling.	/10
Layout and Formatting	Poorly organized, difficult to read, lacks visual appeal.	Adequate organization, readable, lacks consistency.	Well-organized, enhances readability and visual appeal.	/10
Resume				
Job Position Listed	Position not listed or listing unclear.	Position listed but not effectively highlighted.	Clearly listed at the top, prominently highlights target role.	/10
Layout and Formatting	Poorly organized, difficult to read, lacks visual appeal.	Adequate organization, readable, lacks consistency.	Well-organized, enhances readability and visual appeal.	/10
Order of Work/Volunteer History	Not in reverse chronological order, challenging understanding.	Mostly in reverse chronological order, with some inconsistencies.	Completely in reverse chronological order, facilitating clear career progression.	/10
Writing Accuracy	Numerous errors impacting clarity.	Few errors, minor impact on clarity.	Error-free, polished grammar and spelling.	/10
TOTAL TECHNICAL POINTS				/100

725 Interview Skills

Presentation Scoring Rubric

Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-12 points	Meets Expectations 13-25 points	Above Expectations 26-35	Points Awarded
First Impressions	Poor introduction; lacked positive first impression.	Adequate introduction; made a somewhat positive first impression.	Strong introduction; made a very positive first impression.	/35
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-20 points	Above Expectations 21-30 points	Points Awarded
Applicant's Appearance	Not neat or well-groomed; inappropriate attire.	Somewhat neat and well-groomed; acceptable attire.	Neat, well-groomed, and appropriately attired.	/30
Personality and Poise	Negative or insincere demeanor; poor posture and eye contact.	Generally positive and courteous; acceptable posture and eye contact.	Positive, courteous, sincere, confident; good posture and eye contact.	/30
Communication Skills	Poor grammar and pronunciation; unpleasant voice and tone.	Acceptable grammar and pronunciation; generally pleasant voice and tone.	Proper grammar and pronunciation; pleasant voice and tone.	/30
Skills & Qualifications	Lacking required job skills, work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	Demonstrated some required job skills, work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	Demonstrated strong job skills, good work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	/30
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-39 points	Meets Expectations 40-79 points	Above Expectations 80-100 points	Points Awarded
Judges' Questions	Inadequate answers: little to no knowledge of the position or company; lack of initiative.	Acceptable answers: some knowledge of the position and company; demonstrated some initiative.	Appropriate and informed answers; good knowledge of the position and company; demonstrated initiative and enthusiasm.	/100
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-12 points	Meets Expectations 13-25 points	Above Expectations 26-35 points	Points Awarded
Final Impressions	Failed to express thanks or conclude the interview effectively.	Adequately expressed thanks and concluded the interview.	Expressed thanks and concluded the interview effectively.	/35
Documentation	One (1) copy of the Cover Letter and Resume was submitted at presentation check-in (both preliminaries and finals).			/10
TOTAL INTERVIEW POINTS				/300

Note: no more than fifteen (15) minutes for the interview.